

FAST TRACK Sonam Wangchuk with members of Leh Apex Body and Kargil Democratic Alliance

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A FRACTURED CONSTITUENCY

Statehood, and coverage under Sixth Schedule: two clear demands fog up the BJP's windscreen on its Ladakh drive

By Moazum Mohammad

Resistance against the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) for "non-fulfillment of poll promises". Infighting within that party. And cracks within the Opposition INDIA bloc, mirroring the fractured politics of the region. Ladakh may be all of one Lok Sabha constituency, even if India's biggest one, but it bristles with multiple personalities—enough to make 2024 a particularly thorny election season. In the fray are the BJP's Tashi Gyalson, the Congress's Tshering Namgyal and the National Conference's (NC) Haji Hanifa Jan, fighting as an Independent. With an electorate numbering 182,571, Ladakh votes on May 20, against the backdrop of a popular agitation joined by all sides.

The BJP, which had won the seat in the two previous general elections, has fielded Gyalson—a 57-year-old advocate. Challenges for the party include both infighting and anti-incumbency. Soon after Gyalson's candidature was announced, Ladakh's sitting BJP MP, the 1985-born Jamyang Tsering Namgyal, made his displeasure at being overlooked public. While he had hinted at the possibility of contesting as an Independent, he later buried the hatchet and was seen campaigning for Gyalson.

Namgyal's apparent climbdown on the party decision, however, is not enough to comfort the BJP candidate. The party is facing resistance for non-fulfilment of rather core demands: like statehood for Ladakh and its inclusion under Schedule VI of the Indian Constitution (an issue mentioned in the BJP's 2019 manifesto), besides the setting up of a separate public service commission for Ladakh and being allotted two parliamentary seats.

The Sixth Schedule of the Constitution, under Article 244, includes provisions for setting up autonomous councils to safeguard cultural and indigenous identities, manage land use and resources etc. But while Ladakh does have two autonomous hill development councils operating in Leh (since 1995) and Kargil (since 2003) districts, they were set up under a 1995 Act, and not under the Sixth Schedule. The demand for Ladakh's inclusion in the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution has gathered a special intensity owing to an urgent need to protect its fragile ecosystem. Earlier this year, educationist and climate activist Sonam Wangchuk sat on a 21-day fast to highlight the problems facing Ladakh, among them the alarmingly "rapid pace of development projects" being announced in the area since Ladakh was made a Union Territory in 2019. Excessive industrialisation poses a clear and present danger to Ladakh's glaciers, says Wangchuk. His fast was supported by the socio-political organisations Apex Body, Leh, and the Kargil Democratic Association (KDA). According to Padma Stanzin, president of the Ladakh Student Educational & Environmental Action Forum, the youth in Ladakh are also unhappy with the BJP because recruitments for government jobs have allegedly stopped since 2019.

LEH AND KARGIL, BUDDHIST AND MUSLIM, HOLD DIVERGENT POLITICAL STANDS ON MOST ISSUES

Historically, the two districts of Ladakh, Buddhist-dominated Leh and Muslim-majority Kargil have held ideologically and politically divergent stands on most issues. "The two have never formed an electoral alliance in the past nor will it happen now," says Jan, NC district president for Kargil. As part of the division of seats among INDIA partners, the NC received all three Lok Sabha seats in Kashmir, while the Congress got two seats in Jammu and one in Ladakh. The Congress has since fielded Tshering from Ladakh, but the decision has upset the NC's Kargil unit, whose entire top leadership resigned on May 6, alleging they were being pressurised to support Tshering. In a letter to NC chief Farooq Abdullah, party official Qamar Ali Akhoon wrote that Jan will contest the seat as an Independent. "This is why we are demanding separate parliamentary seats for Leh and Kargil. It will end the deep division," says Jan. Now, there may be consensus on that one. ■